

Who votes for Reform UK?

The rapid rise of Reform UK and its subsequent prominence in the current UK party system challenge the traditional understanding that the majority of party systems, including that of the United Kingdom's, were stable by 1920 as a result of the reinforcing church-state and economic cleavages that Lipset and Rokkan (Mair 1990) established with the freezing hypothesis.

Although Reform was founded only in 2018, the Effective Number of Electoral Parties (ENEP) in the UK increased from 3.23 in the 2019 General Election to 4.75 in the 2024 General Election, indicating a major shift in the party system. It seems that Reform UK's newfound prominence in the British party system is paired most deeply with concerns regarding immigration along a new salient social cleavage; voters of Reform thus seem more often to be men, less educated, and perceive themselves as lower class. Attitudes towards immigration and perceived class are the most salient factors that correlate with support for Reform, indicating that the green/alternative/libertarian (GAL)-traditional/authoritarian/nationalist (TAN) cleavage that Ademmer and Stohr (2019) proposed to explain the rise in alternative right-populist parties in Europe, which especially concerns immigration, may be reinforcing across traditional cleavages such as the worker-owner cleavage Lipset and Rokkan had originally proposed.

First, we will establish key definitions necessary to answer the question. Party systems are concerned with which parties exist, the effective number of parties that compete, how big those parties are, and their organizational and electoral strategies. Party systems are largely thought of as being influenced by two factors: (1) the electoral system in place, which influences both strategic entry by political elites and strategic voting by voters, and (2) the latent and politicized social cleavages in a society. Since the electoral system has not shifted dramatically within the time frame of Reform UK's rise, i.e., single-member district pluralities (SMDP) are still used, the discussion is then strictly concerned with which social cleavages have become salient since Reform's founding and what voting demographic coincides with those societal divisions. Reform is a right-populist party on the traditional/authoritarian/nationalist end of the GAL-TAN cleavage, which reflects other anti-immigration, traditionalist parties that have generally gained prominence in Europe (Ademmer and Stohr 2019). The GAL-TAN cleavage is characterized by a polarization over issues concerning European integration and migration; Reform's connection to the GAL-TAN cleavage can be seen by Reform's roots in the Brexit Party and policy preferences concerning restricted immigration, e.g., the STOP THE BOATS! petition. Some key factors for this analysis will then be attitudes towards immigration, national identity, class, and ideology along the left-right social cleavage, as well as other factors like age, gender, and education.

As mentioned above, the ENEP rose from 3.23 in the 2019 General Election to 4.75 in the 2024 General Election, meaning an addition of ~1.5 effective parties gained competitively significant votes in the five years between the general elections. While this is explained in part as the result of a rise in vote share for Reform UK, the Green Party also gained significantly more votes in the 2024 General Election than before (Whiteley 2026), which is characterized by a focus on environmentalism as well as left-wing economic policy, which is also described in the literature as arising from the GAL-TAN cleavage in modern European party systems (Ademmer and Stohr 2019). The rise in these two parties in particular indicates the diminished salience of the

traditional cleavages that dominated the British party system, and that traditional factors that influenced voters to vote either Labour or Conservative are no longer as salient as those along the GAL-TAN cleavage.

Previous work on the question of who votes for Reform found that Reform voters tended to have voted for and have been supportive of Brexit, which is expected due to Reform’s roots in the UK Independence Party and Brexit Party (Heath et al. 2024); 86% of Reform voters had previously voted for the UK to leave the European Union (Goodwin 2024). These voters are generally middle-aged or elderly, marginally more likely to be men, and live outside London and Scotland, typically in England (Goodwin 2024); furthermore, 67% had voted for the Conservative Party in the previous general election, whereas only 4% had voted for Labour. The voting demographic for Reform, then, can be understood as largely a divide within the existing right-wing of the UK party system, where the increased salience of the GAL-TAN cleavage has pushed already ideologically right-wing voters to vote for the right-populist party.

This can be observed empirically in the data; the leftRight variable measures respondents’ political ideology on a scale of 0 to 10, where low values mean that respondents are more left-wing and higher values mean that respondents are more right-wing. The voteReform variable is a dummy variable where the value 1 means that the respondent voted for Reform, and the value 0 means that the respondent did not vote for Reform. Further, the age variable measures age discretely; the gender variable is a dummy variable where a value of 0 represents men and a value of 1 represents women; and educf is a discrete variable where the higher the number, the higher the educational attainment of the respondent.

Table 1	
	<i>Dependent variable:</i>
	voteReform
age	-0.008*** (0.001)
gender	-0.287*** (0.045)
educf	-0.274*** (0.017)
leftRight	0.559*** (0.012)
Constant	-2.906*** (0.148)
Observations	20,094
Log Likelihood	-6,532.630
Akaike Inf. Crit.	13,075.260
Note:	* p<0.1; ** p<0.05; *** p<0.01

Table 1 depicts a multivariate logistic regression model that illustrates how strongly the voteReform model is correlated with age, gender, education, and political ideology; in other words, it illustrates the relationship of different attributes with the log-odd probability of voting for Reform UK. We can utilize the correlation coefficient given in the table to assess the direction and strength of the effect of each independent variable on the likelihood that a

respondent voted for Reform UK. The strongest correlation is with, as is evident in Table 1, the leftRight variable, where a statistically significant positive correlation can be observed at the 1% level, meaning that the more right-wing voters identify, the greater the tendency to vote for Reform. The 0.559 correlation coefficient means that for each unit increase in ideology (representing a shift further towards the right), the log-odds that the respondent would vote for Reform UK increase by 0.559. The standard error of 0.012 implies that recreating the regression model on a sample of the same size would yield an expected variation of 0.012, meaning the regression model's correlation coefficient is reliable. Further findings from this data are that Reform voters weakly tend to be younger in age, and generally seem to be men and have a less educated background.

The empirical evidence is in line with the findings of Goodwin (2024), meaning Reform voters tend to be more right-wing and were thus traditionally represented by the Conservative Party in the British party system. However, while this model predicts the probability of voting for Reform based on the provided independent variables, it does not prove causality; as such, it illustrates the general trend that right-wing voters more often vote for Reform, but does not tell us the causal link as to why. Further, given the SMDP electoral system of the United Kingdom, per Duverger's Law and strategic voting, it is unclear as to why right-wing voters would abandon the already dominant Conservative Party to vote for Reform. We then must answer the question as to why right-wing voters are leaving the Conservative Party to vote for Reform, even when it is strategically not in their best interest.

Utilizing a data set made available by the British Election Study (BES), we assess factors generally associated with the GAL-TAN cleavage and respondents' party affiliation, specifically responses to the questions,

1. "Do you think that too many immigrants have been let into this country, or not?"
Represented by a dummy variable where 0 represents the stance that "Immigration is not an issue" and 1 represents the stance that "Immigration is an issue" [immig]
2. What is the total annual income of your household from all sources before tax - including benefits, savings and so on? [income]
3. Most people say they belong either to the middle class or to the working class. If you had to make a choice, would you call yourself middle class or working class? Where 0 is working class, 1 is middle class, and 2 is upper class. [class]
4. Which, if any, of the following best describes how you see yourself? Evaluated on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 is more English and 5 is less English. [v04]

A multivariate logistic regression model of the above factors with the dependent variables of aligning with Reform UK (Table 2) and the Conservative Party (Table 3) yields the following results.

Table 2

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>
	alignReform
immig	2.184** (1.042)
income	0.063 (0.065)
class	-1.763** (0.764)
v04	-0.387 (0.238)
Constant	-3.771*** (1.341)
Observations	415
Log Likelihood	-71.409
Akaike Inf. Crit.	152.818

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 3

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>
	alignConservative
immig	1.152*** (0.266)
income	0.043 (0.031)
class	0.290 (0.234)
v04	-0.007 (0.112)
Constant	-2.181*** (0.503)
Observations	415
Log Likelihood	-237.420
Akaike Inf. Crit.	484.840

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

The factors that seem to influence the probability to align with Reform the most are attitudes towards immigration ('immig'), with a correlation coefficient of 2.184 for Reform voters and 1.152 for Conservative voters, as well as perceived class ('class'), with a correlation coefficient of -1.763 for Reform voters and 0.290 for Conservative voters. In fact, perceived class is positively correlated with voters aligned with the Conservative Party, whereas it is negatively correlated with voters aligned with Reform UK. Furthermore, the correlation between perceived class and alignment with the Conservative Party is not statistically significant even at the 10% level, indicating that class is not a significant predictive factor in determining the probability that a voter aligns themselves with the Conservative Party. This supports findings by Whiteley (2026) that found that Reform UK, compared to the Green Party, does not appeal to middle-class voters, and indicates that class is a more salient issue among voters leaving the Conservative Party to vote for Reform UK. This aligns with the literature on the development of the GAL-TAN cleavage, where middle-class voters since the 1980s have been drawn to "post-material" issues such as environmentalism (Clark, Golder, and Golder 2024), and where individuals that may identify with a lower class feel that material issues are no longer being represented by the political elite, due to elite capture, prompting the response of right populist parties to "green" parties, resulting in the salience of the GAL-TAN cleavage.

The strongest correlation, however, is that between immigration attitudes and alignment with Reform UK. Compared with other indicators tested, it has the greatest predictive power for determining whether a respondent votes for Reform.

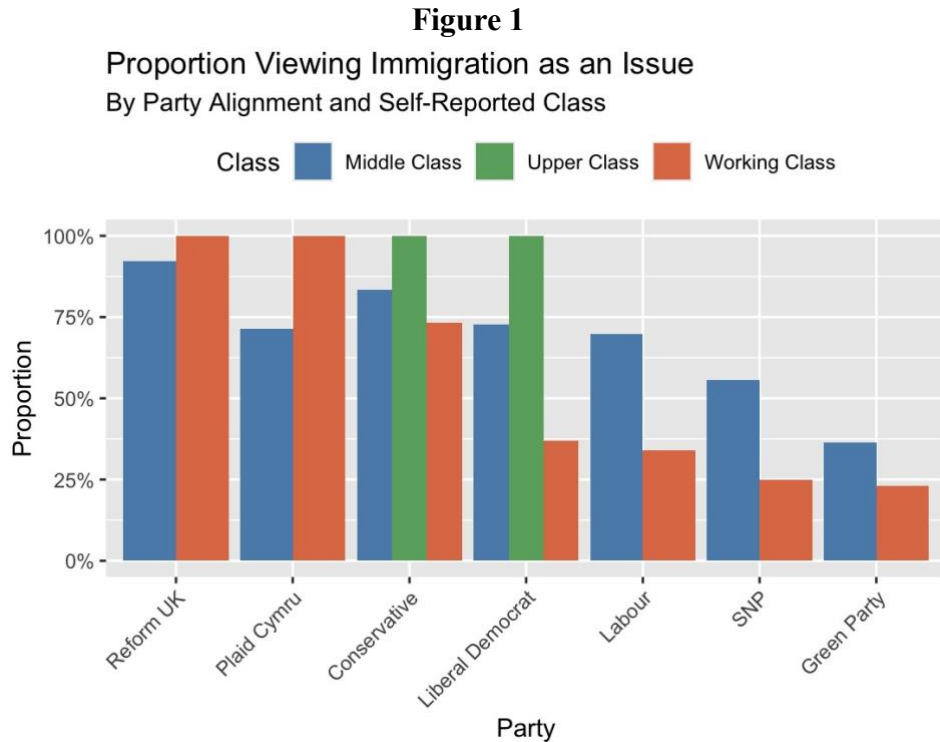


Figure 1 illustrates the proportion of voters who answered that “Too many immigrants have been let into this country” for each major party in the UK. Reform had the highest proportion of respondents answering that immigration is an issue in both the middle and working classes, and has a higher proportion between the two classes than the Conservative Party, the Labour Party, and the Green Party. This figure illustrates that immigration is a salient factor in determining who votes for Reform insofar as cutting down on immigration seems to represent a greater policy issue for Reform voters than voters of either of the two traditionally dominant parties, and especially more so than the Green Party, which represents the opposing cleavage group along the GAL-TAN cleavage.

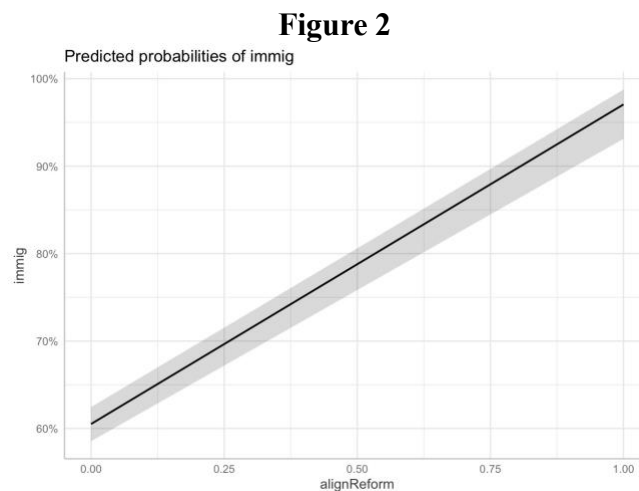


Table 4

Predicted probabilities of immig		
alignReform	Predicted	95% CI
0	0.61	0.59, 0.62
1	0.97	0.93, 0.99

Figure 2 shows the predicted probabilities of responding that “Too many immigrants have been let into this country” given voting for Reform. From the figure, we can observe that the more aligned with Reform UK a voter is, the greater the likelihood they have negative attitudes towards immigration. Respondents who did not vote for Reform had a 0.61 probability of responding that “too many immigrants have been let into this country,” whereas respondents who did had a 0.97 probability of responding in that way. This finding seems to emphasize the importance that attitudes towards immigration have on voting Reform, given that Reform voters have a near-100% probability of having negative attitudes towards immigration, reinforcing the salience of the GAL-TAN cleavage on issues regarding migration and European integration (Ademmer and Stohr 2019). Since these are descriptive findings, however, it is difficult to establish a causal relationship between whether it was the salience of the GAL-TAN cleavage to begin with that led to the rise of Reform UK or if it was the politicization of a latent GAL-TAN social cleavage that reinforced existing cleavages that led to the rise of Reform. However, we can still conclude that voters who hold anti-immigration sentiments are more likely to vote for Reform based on the data presented above.

In conclusion, voters for Reform are characterized best by three factors: they (1) tend to be ideologically right-leaning, (2) tend to perceive themselves as lower class than other right-leaning voters, and (3) tend to have negative attitudes towards immigration. Overall, attitudes towards immigration have the strongest correlation with voting Reform, with a logistic correlation coefficient of 2.184; class and ideology are also salient factors, with correlation coefficients of -1.763 and 0.559, respectively. These factors are accounted for in the literature as salient along a new green/alternative/libertarian (GAL)-traditional/authoritarian/nationalist (TAN) or materialist-post materialist cleavage, which explains the fracturing of the British party system represented by the rise of Reform UK.

Works Cited

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Appendix

Effective Number of Electoral Parties (ENEP) Calculations:¹ 2019

$$N = \frac{1}{\sum_{i=1}^n p_i^2} = \frac{1}{0.436^2 + 0.322^2 + 0.039^2 + 0.115^2 + 0.008^2 + 0.006^2 + 0.005^2 + 0.004^2 + 0.027^2 + 0.004^3 + 0.020^2 + 0.003^2 + 0.001^2 + 0.001^2} \approx 3.23$$

2024

$$N = \frac{1}{\sum_{i=1}^n p_i^2} = \frac{1}{0.337^2 + 0.237^2 + 0.122^2 + 0.025^2 + 0.007^2 + 0.143^2 + 0.006^2 + 0.067^2 + 0.007^2 + 0.003^3 + 0.004^2 + 0.003^2 + 0.002^2 + 0.007^2 + 0.001^2 + 0.001^2} \approx 4.75$$

```
install.packages("stargazer")
```

```
install.packages("tidyverse")
```

```
library(tidyverse)
```

```
library(stargazer)
```

```
install.packages("haven")
```

```
library(haven) require(haven)
```

```
install.packages("ggeffects")
```

```
library(ggeffects)
```

```
# Use the reformdata.dta dataset reformdata
```

```
<- read_dta("reformdata.dta")
```

```
# Create variables for Reform voters (as y values must be 0 <= y <=1)
```

```
reformdata$voteReform <- NA reformdata$voteReform[reformdata$reformUK
```

```
== 1] <- 0 reformdata$voteReform[reformdata$reformUK == 2] <- 1
```

```
# Logistic Correlation of voteReform with age, gender, education, and ideology table1 <-
```

```
glm(voteReform ~ age + gender + educf + leftRight, data = reformdata, family =
```

```
"binomial") summary(table1)
```

```
stargazer(table1, type = "text")
```

```
# Use the BES data besdata <-
```

```
read_dta("bes_reform.dta")
```

```
# Clean values in the raw data besdata[besdata
```

```
== 9999] <- NA besdata[besdata == -1] <-
```

```
NA
```

```
# Creation of the 'alignReform' dummy variable
```

```
besdata$alignReform <- NA besdata$alignReform[besdata$d01
```

```
== 8] <- 1 besdata$alignReform[besdata$d01 %in%
```

```
c(0,1,2,3,4,5,6,7,9)] <- 0
```

```
# Creation of the 'alignConservative' dummy variable
```

```
besdata$alignConservative <- NA besdata$alignConservative[besdata$d01
```

¹ Data From: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/election/2024/uk/results>


```
== 2] <- 1 besdata$alignConservative[besdata$d01 %in%  
c(0,1,3,4,5,6,7,8,9)] <- 0
```

```
# Creating the 'immig' variable besdata$immig[besdata$j05 == 2] <-  
0 # Immigration is not an issue besdata$immig[besdata$j05 == 1] <-  
1 # Immigration is an issue
```

```
# Correlation of alignReform with Immigration Survey Question  
immigrationImportance <- lm(data = besdata, formula = alignReform ~ immig)  
summary(immigrationImportance) stargazer(immigrationImportance, type =  
"text")
```

```
# Creating the 'income' variable besdata$income[besdata$y01  
== 1] <- 1 besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 2] <- 2  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 3] <- 3  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 4] <- 4  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 5] <- 5  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 6] <- 6  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 7] <- 7  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 8] <- 8  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 9] <- 9  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 10] <- 10  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 11] <- 11  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 12] <- 12  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 13] <- 13  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 14] <- 14  
besdata$income[besdata$y01 == 15] <- 15
```

```
# Creating the 'class' variable besdata$class[besdata$w02 == 1] <- 1  
besdata$class[besdata$w02 == 2] <- 0 # this is to make sure the class variable progresses in  
terms of income besdata$class[besdata$w02 == 3] <- 2
```

```
# Clean values in v04 besdata$v04[besdata$v04 %in%  
c(-999, -1, 6, 7)] <- NA
```

```
# Logistic Correlation of alignReform with stance on Immigration as well as Income  
modelReform <- glm(alignReform ~ immig + income + class + v04, data = besdata, family =  
"binomial") summary(modelReform)  
stargazer(modelReform, type = "text")
```

```
# Logistic Correlation of alignReform with stance on Immigration as well as Income  
modelConservative <- glm(alignConservative ~ immig + income + class + v04, data = besdata,  
family = "binomial") summary(modelConservative) stargazer(modelConservative, type =  
"text")
```

Plot for Party Alignment vs Attitudes on Immigration

```
besdata$party <- NA besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 1]
<- "Labour" besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 2] <-
"Conservative" besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 3] <-
"Liberal Democrat" besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 4] <-
"SNP" besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 5] <- "Plaid
Cymru" besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 6] <- "Green
Party" besdata$party[besdata$d01 == 8] <- "Reform
UK"
```

```
besdata$class_label <- NA besdata$class_label[besdata$class
== 0] <- "Middle Class" besdata$class_label[besdata$class
== 1] <- "Working Class" besdata$class_label[besdata$class
== 2] <- "Upper Class"
```

```
ggplot(plot_data, aes(x = reorder(party, -prop_immig), y = prop_immig, fill = class_label)) +
geom_bar(stat = "identity", position = "dodge") + scale_y_continuous(labels =
scales::percent_format(accuracy = 1), limits = c(0, 1)) + scale_fill_manual(values =
c("Working Class" = "#E07B54",
    "Middle Class" = "#5B8DB8",
    "Upper Class" = "#6AAB6E")) + labs(title = "Proportion Viewing
Immigration as an Issue", subtitle = "By Party Alignment and Self-Reported Class", x =
"Party", y = "Proportion", fill = "Class" ) + theme(axis.text.x = element_text(angle = 45,
hjust = 1), legend.position = "top")
```

```
# Prediction Table - immig modelImmig <- glm(immig ~ alignReform, data =
besdata, family = "binomial") summary(modelImmig)
```

```
predictImmig <- ggpredict(modelImmig, terms = "alignReform[0:1] by=1")
print_html(predictImmig)
```

```
graph_predictImmig <- ggpredict(modelImmig, terms="alignReform")
plot(graph_predictImmig)
```